Gentrification – A Collection

By Angy Rivera, Bobby Lefebre and Niveli Travaski

INTRODUCTION

Since the age of 4, Angy Rivera has lived in the United States with a secret that threatens to upend her life: She is undocumented. Angy arrived with her mother, fleeing violence, poverty, and civil war in their native Colombia. For 20 years they live in the shadows, struggling to stay afloat financially and avoid deportation while battling a complex and inequitable immigration system and an urban landscape of gentrification.

***Gentrification** - when the character of a poor urban area is changed by wealthier people moving in, improving housing, and attracting new businesses, typically displacing current inhabitants in the process.*

Gentrification – A Collection including "Community Not Condominiums by Angy Rivera; "Push Out (aka Denver, Where Have You Gone)" by Bobby Lefebre; and "Eviction" by Niyeli Trovaski

Community Not Condominiums by Angy Rivera

Dona Maria is up before the sun rises

It's her job to feed others.

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Arepas made with corn and cheese

Tamales wrapped up in leaves

Authentic café from the hills of Colombia

Packed in her food truck she makes her way down

Roosevelt Avenue.

Dona Maria knows these streets like her hands

Cracked and calloused.

The same streets she has walked up and down with her

family on hot summer nights.

(Spoken in various customer voices)

¿A cuánto los tamales?

Un café por favor sin azúcar

Solo una arepa hoy porque estoy cuidando mi figura

¡Hola Doña María como esta de bonita hoy!

***¿Y sus hijos como están?** **

Questions comments and food orders

This is the routine

What puts food on the table.

There are no strangers here.

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(Scene shifts to speaker on the subway)

Last stop last stop

Stand clear of the closing doors

Two blocks up from the last stop you can buy
four dollar sushi roles

Hot pot dinners

Fried and steamed dumplings

Buy 1 get 1 free taro, coconut, apple, chocolate, mango
bubble teas milk tea, and green tea

Busy mall

Chinese New Year

Dim sum

Moon festivals

Red decorations

Admiring the dragon racing up and down the streets

It's a tradition

There are no strangers here

This is community

How will Doña MarÍa sell her tamales, arepas, café y
chocolate

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When the streets become businesses she cannot
pronounce

Will her café con leche compete with Starbucks?

These signs of a cleaner and safer Queens erase the
resiliency already here

We weren't dirty to begin with

Will her house stand untouched during gentrification?

My childhood is splattered across the windows of houses
and buildings in Queens

Woodside, Corona, Elmhurst, Roosevelt and Flushing

Home away from home

The only communities that have nurtured my growth

Where I met Mexican and Dominican food

Where I learned to play dominoes and heard Bachata**
playing from the neighbor's window

(Could insert a short acapella excerpt from a song)

Home away from home

Where I was welcomed since I was 4

Español spoken on my block I never felt alone or scared

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Community not condominiums

There are no strangers here

Doña MarÍa packs up her truck

Her casita awaits

Tomorrow will be a new day

Filled with hopes that these streets will always

stay the same

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Angy Rivera
On-line only - Check for publication requirements at your tournament before performing
Publisher: The Ultimate Queens Newsletter
Date (Month/Year): July 15, 2014

Full Poem can be found here
https://qns.com/wp-content/uploads/2014/07/COMMUNITY-NOT-CONDOMINIUMS4.pdf

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Push Out (aka Denver, Where Have You Gone) by Bobby Lefebre

I remember when my neighborhood

was just called the North side

Now they are calling it the "Highlands".

They're calling it progress....

Progress on the same Barrio streets those people once warned their children to stay away from.

They say it is an evolution..... as if what had existed there before was somehow subhuman

My neighborhood had history

Old Impalas and Monte Carlos have become Mercedes

Parking spots have been invaded by SUV's and I have to drive to get Mexican food.

They removed the tennis shoes

from the power line yesterday,

painted over a mural of La Virgin de Guadalupe, and closed out another Brown-owned business .....they replaced it with a "doggie daycare".

Now the Police interaction with the changing demographic is smiles and handshakes

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Gentrification is as compassionate as a suicide bomber
detonating in a preschool schoolyard.
the pushers discuss popular culture
in an overpriced eatery
that used to be
a shop that sold herbal remedies
for people too poor for doctors and prescriptions
They have placed streetlamps
along the same walkways
where the darkness of night provided a shield for drug
deals, graffiti ridden walls have been painted over,
trashcans have been added to every corner,
and there is even a contraption
on the light post that carries baggies
for dog s***.
All of this in the name of beautifying the Barrio
All of this was asked for before
but back then.....
it was only dirty Mexicans asking;
if they wanted a better neighborhood then why didn't
they just move?

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Now don't get me wrong,
the barrio I knew
was not an ideal place for a flower to grow
There is nothing beautiful about drug deals and Brown
on Brown crime.
Nothing luring bout' streets filled with litter and
disproportionate
illiteracy rates.
Living paycheck to paycheck has never been fashionable
There was beauty in the struggle though
before long, these people will have nowhere to go
I received the call yesterday
My landlord informed me he is "negotiating" a deal to
sell the property
on which my apartment sits
A deal that would leave him with a profit and us
packing.....
We have started to collect boxes

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Bobby Lefebre
On-line only - Check for publication requirements at your tournament before performing
Publisher: Buzzfeed.com (NSDA Approved Website)
Date (Month/Year): May 14, 2020

On-line Location
https://www.buzzfeed.com/laurasteinberg88/poetry-about-what-home-means-3trqk1ektv

Eviction by Niyeli Trovaski

one more beautiful day
in the City of San Francisco
with its bridges and the bay
perfect hour for an eviction
oh San Francisco,
once the city of poets
Presidio swept clean -- museums expanded --
old hotels purified of the poor, shadows vaulted
into unknown precincts beyond the gate
picture pristine and proper neighborhoods
enjoy sterile rows of research and development --
learn to live forever and never face decrepitude --

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a new breed of chefs
concoct salmon salad on an arugula bedding,
Zinfandel secreted in a rib eye steak --
wine bars where the decision-makers
nod as the wine is poured, sloshed in a glass,

yes excellent

dispossession is a misery the rich do not need to see,
they may root for the Giants -- take pride in the signs
of progress -- hit the ball out of the park
and hearts swell past a vacated room that once gave
shelter

those of you who must go
leave in silence, please make the premises
clean as you walk out of the front door,
don't steal anything

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Author: Niyeli Trovaski
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Publisher: Buzzfeed.com (NSDA Approved Website)
Date (Month/Year): May 14, 2020

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(Echo from Community Not Condominiums)

¿A cuánto los tamales?

Un café por favor sin azúcar

Solo una arepa hoy porque estoy cuidando mi figura

¡Hola Doña María como esta de bonita hoy!

¿Y sus hijos como están?*

Community not condominiums

There are no strangers here

AWARD HISTORY

2020 National Qualifier - MS

Translation:
How much are the tamales?
A coffee please without sugar
Just one arepa today because I'm taking care of my figure
Hello Doña María, how beautiful you are today!
And how are your children?

*** Bachata Music Sample***
https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=OrCUjqQYS3U

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